WARNING ORDER:

OPERATION BARNABAS

OCTOBER 2023

OPERATION BARNABAS

Operation Barnabas is the LCMS' network of care to our nation's military members, families and veterans. We reach out to all branches of the military with a special emphasis on our Reserve members and their families.

LUKE 16:13

No servant can serve two masters, for either he will hate the one and love the other, or he will be devoted to the one and despise the other. You cannot serve God and money.



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A LESSON ABOUT SALVATION DISGUISED AS MONEY TALK

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The parable in Luke 16:1–8 that causes many a preacher to run for a "free text." The excuses are amazing: "It is too difficult." "It's hard to swallow." Some theologians who discuss this text politely call it "difficult." A stellar writer and theologian of The Lutheran Church—Missouri Synod, the Rev. Dr. Arthur Just, calls this section, "The Prudent Servant of Unrighteousness in Matters of Faith." A popular, scholarly preacher of our day expresses agitation at this parable and says, "Let's look at this parable, discuss it and get on with it!" as if the parable in Luke 16:1–8 were an invasive medical procedure, an expensive car repair or a confrontation with a colleague that predictably ends in a "train wreck."



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So, I get the apprehension. But at the end of the day, it is important for us to acknowledge the fact that these are the words of Jesus. They mandate our attention. It is the Lord God who tells us to "give ear to Jesus:"

> *He was still speaking when, behold, a bright cloud overshadowed them, and a voice from the cloud said, "This is my beloved Son, with whom I am well pleased; listen to him."* **(MATT. 17:5)**

This is the same Lord who suffered on a cross for all humanity, the Savior who redeemed us from death. It is this Jesus who crushes the grave and promises to forever claim us as His own, that we may live with Him forever.

So, what makes this parable so difficult? My best guess is based on my many years of pastoral care and careful study of Scripture: Jesus is talking about money. The topic of wealth, money and possessions is cited 2,300 times in the Bible![1] Among such passages are 1 Timothy 6:10:

> *For the love of money is a root of all kinds of evils. It is through this craving that some have wandered away from the faith and pierced themselves with many pangs.*

The topic of money makes many squirm. How we spend, what we spend, where we spend our money says a lot about us. How we lose our money or how we gain financial

[1] *https://www.biblemoney.net/how-many-times-does-the-bible-warn-about-money*

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REPORTS

J-1 Personnel
Roll Call: Gather names and record attendance of members. A time to get to know each other.

J-2 Intelligence
Gather and share information. Provide a report on local units and their deployment schedule; also provide contact information for local military contacts upon request. Identify and assess what is going on in the community concerning veterans and their families.

J-3 Operations and Training
Develop a plan. Draft a listing of possible chapter activities, including veterans celebrations, presentations (as desired and available); develop a strategy to expand outreach into the community. Identify and assign tasks to specific people that include standards and timeframes.

J-4 Logistics
Identify and provide materials for meetings, such as coffee, refreshments, etc., to support the plan.

J-6 Communication
Develop communication strategies to support the plan. Place internal announcements (newsletter/bulletins) as well as provide articles for the local paper.

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wealth often becomes a highly volatile topic. Think of the time when someone you know and love lost a great deal of money on an investment. Think of the time a colleague told you with great pride their income is rooted on their love of work! Perhaps you remember a time when someone you know was scammed. The Lord of All knows all about humanity. Jesus recognizes that we tie so much to money and wealth. In many ways, money enters the realm of faith, belief and trust in God. We know with confidence we should not equate money with salvation and one's standing with the Lord. (For further insight, please read Luke 16:19 about the rich man and Lazarus.) Wealth is not a guarantee of contentment. The book of Ecclesiastes speaks to this topic:

> *He who loves money will not be satisfied with money, nor he who loves wealth with his income; this also is vanity.* **(ECCL. 5:10)**

This parable also makes us uncomfortable because it reminds us of where the incarnate Christ travels to redeem humanity. This makes us squirm and assaults our pious sensibilities from the Lord. Yes, Jesus is talking about money. How earthy! How plebeian, how beneath our Lord. Yes, He uses a parable about a seemingly underhanded manager, a steward of a wealthy businessman. Sure, the manager is caught "cooking the books!" He was seized for padding his own account and as a result was fired.

Big problem. We are sinners. We mold Jesus into our preferred image. "My Jesus is soft, tender, and mild! How would he even know about a white-collar criminal?" Along this false argument is, "No, I prefer Jesus the Good Shepherd, not that I know any shepherds." In our fallen humanity, we prefer Jesus as the kindly, naive Savior who fills our lives with sunshine and roses, a Lord who would never look at or explore the underbelly of humanity, the place of vulgar darkness where humanity's ugliness festers and grows. Now comes the demonstration of our need for a Savior. Many think, "It's fine for us to know about thieves, robbers, hucksters and manipulators, scammers and the like." This line of thought demonstrates our own brokenness and daily need of repentance. We get so uncomfortable when Jesus throws a reality check in our face like a bucket of icy water.

The parable in Luke 16:1–8 has much to offer. Parables have "turns" which highlight the point of the story. Here are the highlights. Jesus tells a parable of a financial manager. Stewards, or people trusted to care for and manage wealth, are not uncommon. Their job is to maximize the dollar of the owner.

Well, the steward got caught wasting his master's hard-earned cash. This is unforgivable. He's told in clear terms to clean up the books and hand them over. But the steward has a powerful tool at his disposal — time! Time to gain friends and influence by softening the debt of various vendors. He seeks out those who buy and sell with his boss. Every client and vendor he encounters, the steward cuts their bill, sometimes as much as 50%. Many see this as one the parable's points. We are called to use our time wisely. Although this appears minor, the use of time is a stepping stone to additional concepts the Lord teaches.



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When the last big meeting in the owner's office occurs, you would think the steward would have a serious reckoning where he would give an account for all his misdeeds. I would envision a room full of agencies: a representative from the FTC, a fraud squad from the local police, perhaps a couple of pencil-neck bank examiners, an IRS agent. Instead, it's just the steward and the owner. What does he do? Not what you expect. The wealthy proprietor gives him a big verbal bear hug! How shrewd! How manipulative! How commendable!

Jesus is making a point to us, His redeemed children. How aggressive, how shrewd are you when it comes to growing in the Word of God? Do you use every tool in your toolbox to hold onto Holy Scripture? Do you use the vise grips of tenacity to take time out of your day for meditation on God's Word? Do you fight through physical pain to attend worship? Participate in the Sacraments despite disruptions in harmony at our church? The parable is not addressed to the financial whiz-kids of Jesus' day, nor is it intended for the learned scholars, interpreters of Scripture who can twist every line of God's Word to benefit themselves.

This parable is for you. The first verse of Luke 16 says, "He also said to the disciples." That is you. This is a formal accusation and requires an answer.

The second point of the parable is the calling of Jesus to be that prudent steward of unrighteousness. The steward's self-assessment showed that he lacked strength, was full of shame, and needed to look outside himself for help.

Thus, compounding the call to wake up our "God-given tenacity" is also the need to look beyond ourselves for help regarding our salvation. The plea of the steward may indeed be wrongheaded. Buying favors in hopes of a continued great life never works out. But we know full well our eternal hope comes from outside of us. In many ways, this parable of the steward reminds me of Jesus' engagement with the centurion recorded in Matthew 8. It is a powerful event. Consider the Roman leader: he was wealthy, a leader of men, and standing atop the pinnacle of society. But all of his wealth, power and status cannot save. In the centurion's case it was his servant that needed saving. In our case, it is our very soul. We need to look to Christ who saves us. Every day.

The next point of the parable is a challenge to our own character and loyalty. What Jesus says accuses us, as parables often do. The Lord challenges us by asking, "Are you a disciplined Christian?" This reminds me of an event that occurred a couple of days ago. I was talking to a very sharp and articulate man, a future pastor and probably budding theologian of our church. We were working meticulously to resolve a pastoral care topic. It was thorough and slow-going, like using an icepick to cut down a tree. We had been at it for about three hours. The conversation required a lot of concentration and it was getting close to lunch. I told him, "Man, I admire your skills and patience. But we need to take a break." I humorously told him it is no fun to be around a cranky chaplain. That sharp man responded without skipping a beat and said, "This is now the best time to work together. I can learn more about you when you are tired and hungry than at any other time!"

It's curious that his litmus for predictable, authentic behavior is when one is at a sugar-low and fatigued. However, I wasn't bothered. I am used to that and it's not foreign to me. My time in the army brings about living with periodic intervals of deprivation including food and sleep. So, who am I to disagree with a budding theologian and the army?

The parable of the prudent steward of unrighteousness teaches us, as redeemed children of God, to be tenacious, inventive, aggressive about all aspects of our faith, and at the end of the day, open our hearts and harness our behavior with discipline to listen to the Lord and give with joy.

In this wonderful parable, Jesus desires for us, His children, to explore a different litmus. It regards money. Where is your heart? Where is your wallet and purse? This is best put in the form of a question: "Can a rich man, an unbeliever, be a big giver and as such get into heaven?" The answer is clearly no. But Jesus also teaches that a believer who places his treasure elsewhere may have just as slim a chance.

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RESOURCES

LCMS Ministry to the Armed Forces
lcms.org/ministry-to-the-armed-forces

Military Chaplaincy (LCMS):
The link below provides an excellent introductory view of the exciting life and opportunities of the military chaplaincy.

- If Not Us, Then Who?: *vimeo.com/208556248*

Operation Barnabas logo wear by Lands' End
Clothing and other items with the Operation Barnabas logo can be purchased from Lands' End:
business.landsend.com/store/lcms-maf-ob

Combined Arms (CAX)
Combined Arms (CAX) is a nonprofit organization exclusively focused on transforming the veteran services marketplace (public & private) to improve the lives of veterans and military families: *combinedarms.us*

VA Medical Foster Home Program for Veterans
The VA now supports over 1,000 veterans in 700 foster homes in 42 states. This resource provides certified care for veterans needing supervision 24 hours a day, 7 days a week: *blogs.va.gov/VAntage/69916/veterans-gain-freedom-fuller-lives-under-foster-home-program/*

"Veteran-Friendly Community" program
The VA is seeking to enhance services to veterans through their "Veteran-Friendly Community" program. Please see this link for more information: *va.gov/ve/engagement/index.asp*

Also available is the Veteran Community Partnerships Toolkit. This resource aids in the development of community partnerships with the VA.

Veteran Help
If you are a veteran or you know a veteran who may be in crisis, free confidential support is available 24/7. Call the Veterans Crisis Line at 988 and press 1, send a text message to 838255 or chat online: *veteranscrisisline.net/get-help/chat*

National Chaplain Center
patientcare.va.gov/chaplain/index.asp

U.S. Department of Veterans Affairs *va.gov*

National Guard Office of the Chaplain
nationalguard.mil/Leadership/Joint-Staff/Special-Staff/Chaplain/

National Military Family Association *militaryfamily.org*

U.S. Air Force Chaplain Corps *af.mil*

U.S. Army Chaplaincy *army.mil/chaplaincorps/*

Organize a donation drive for homeless veterans
Access the step-by-step guide at *va.gov/HOMELESS/docs/FaithBasedDonationDrive-508.pdf.*

OUTREACH TO THE MILITARY COMMUNITY



Photo: LCMS/Erik M. Lunsford

Operation Barnabas congregations can honor and support their military-connected members in various ways. Some of the projects that have been successful, and may help fill a need in your community, are listed below.

CREATING A WALL OF HONOR. Collect pictures and/or names of the veterans in your congregation and design a board to showcase their service. You may also dedicate this board using a template provided by Ministry to the Armed Forces (MAF).

MAILING CARE PACKAGES. Mail care packages to deployed LCMS chaplains and the service members at their location. For a list of recommended items or mailing addresses, contact Alicia Hinton at *alicia.hinton@lcms.org*.

HOLDING A VA FORUM. Call your local Veteran's Administration representative and ask them to come and speak about important topics such as benefits and special programs.

SERVICE OF THANKSGIVING. Hold a service of thanksgiving for the veterans in your community. Some examples include a hosting a July 4th BBQ or Veterans Day Dinner, or acknowledging their service on MAF Sunday.

DINNER FOR STUDENT VETERANS. Reach out to students who are veterans at your local college. Offer to cook a "home-cooked meal" for them.

MANNING A BOOTH. Secure a booth at your local fair/event and discuss how Operation Barnabas can support the military community. For flyers/giveaways, contact MAF.



Contributed photos

FALLEN HEROES



MARINE CPL. SPENCER R. COLLART
21, of Arlington, Va., died Aug. 27 in an MV-22 Osprey crash in Australia during a multinational training exercise. Collart was a crew chief assigned to the Marine Rotational Force – Darwin. He joined the Marine Corps in Oct. 2020 and previously served in Pensacola, Fla. and Jacksonville, N.C. His awards include the National Defense Service Medal, Global War on Terrorism Service Medal, and Sea Service Deployment Ribbon. The incident is currently under investigation.



MARINE CAPT. ELEANOR V. LEBEAU
29, of Belleville, Ill., died Aug. 27 in an MV-22 Osprey crash in Australia during a multinational training exercise. LeBeau was an Osprey pilot assigned to the Marine Rotational Force – Darwin. She commissioned in the Marine Corps in August 2018 and previously served in Pensacola, Fla., Corpus Christi, Texas, and Jacksonville, N.C. Her awards include the National Defense Service Medal, Global War on Terrorism Service Medal, and Sea Service Deployment Ribbon. The incident is currently under investigation.



MARINE MAJ. TOBIN J. LEWIS
37, of Jefferson, Colo., died Aug. 27 in a MV-22 Osprey crash in Australia during a multinational training exercise. Lewis was an Osprey pilot assigned to the Marine Rotational Force – Darwin and was the executive officer of Marine Medium Tiltrotor Squadron 363, Kaneohe Bay, Hawaii. He commissioned in the Marine Corps in August 2008 and previously served in Pensacola, Fla., Corpus Christi, Texas, Jacksonville, N.C, and Okinawa, Japan. His awards include two Navy and Marine Corps Commendation Medals, the Navy and Marine Corps Achievement Medal, Navy Unit Commendation, National Defense Service Medal, Global War on Terrorism Expeditionary Medal, Global War on Terrorism Service Medal, and four Sea Service Deployment Ribbons. The incident is currently under investigation.



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DAYS TO REMEMBER OCTOBER



— OCT. 13 —
Navy Birthday

— OCT. 26 —
National Day of the Deployed

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Luther preached on this text on multiple occasions. In the context of this sermon, Luther wants the hearers to distinguish truth from false religion:

> *Look for a fellow of whom greed has really taken possession. You will find that his thoughts grant him rest neither day or night; all his ponder and planning are directed at making money. If he finds a little corner of his house, he converts it into a room in order to collect rent. In a word, he would not neglect to collect one penny; nor does he begrudge any effort of labor when he sees the possibility of earning money. Now we should learn to interest ourselves in the eternal with the earnestness with which the miser himself concerns himself with money. But where do you find the Christian who does this?*[2]

Be the prudent servant of unrighteousness in matters of faith. Tenacious! Inventive, creative, aggressive. Be like the miser, who, though condemned by sin to hell, hungers and thirsts for righteousness, and is already in the arms of our Savior and guarded by the Holy Spirit. Find the full depth and treasures given by Jesus. In Jesus' name. Amen.

[2] Foreword by Martin H. Scharlemann. "What Luther Says" Concordia Publishing House. Citation 810

OPERATION BARNABAS

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We want to hear from you! If you've got ideas for future issues, comments, feedback on articles you've read in *Warning Order* or news from your part of the world, please let us know. Write to *alicia.hinton@lcms.org* with your stories, and be sure to include your name, city and state.

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The Lutheran Church Missouri Synod
Ministry to the Armed Forces

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PRAYER



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POISED ON THE BRINK OF TRANSITION

ALMIGHTY AND EVER-LIVING GOD, we thank You for this day and all the blessings You give us. We thank You for the gift of Your Son, Jesus, who gave us life on the cross by His bitter suffering and death. Lord God, we have entered a month of transition. The weather is cooling, and crops have entered their final phase of growth. Soon we anticipate the harvest. Summer is over. Schools are running. Universities are back in session, and churches are preparing for fall festivals. You give this month to us as a gift of gentle transition, a reminder of seasons in our life.

I pray that You abide with me as I go through transition. The change of season reminds me of chapters in my life. The harvest stands as a reflection of the cycle of life. Education institutions starting is a reminder that we are always life-long learners.

Almighty God, for Jesus' sake, I thank You that You are with us as we continually go through life's transitions. We know that no matter how difficult or smooth, You are present always. As we look at seasons and times of the year, we are reminded of the wise teacher of Ecclesiastes who wrote: "For everything there is a season, and a time for every matter under heaven" (ECCL. 3:1). We know of life and death, war and peace, laughter and mourning. We also rest confidently in the words of Paul who wrote: "For if we live, we live to the Lord, and if we die, we die to the Lord. So then, whether we live or whether we die, we are the Lord's." (ROM. 14:8). Continue to grant us comfort as we transition through the chapters of life. Be with us as we move from this temporal life to life everlasting, resting in You forever.

In Jesus' name. **AMEN.**